

Perez's downward trajectory over the last two seasons prompted the think tank to replace him with Lawson. The Kiwi racer competed in the final six races of the 2024 season at Racing Bulls, replacing Ricciardo.

Lawson displayed flashes of brilliance during his short stint in F1, especially during his wheel-to-wheel battle with two-time World Champion Fernando Alonso in Austin. But the 22-year-old was overshadowed at the back end of last season by teammate Yuki Tsunoda, particularly in qualifying, where the Japanese driver enjoyed a 6-0 head-to-head record.

Tsunoda could yet be breathing down the New Zealander's neck, and if the latter fails to get going as quickly as the team expects, there could be another mid-season swap on the cards.

Oliver Bearman

Oliver Bearman (**above**) needs no introduction in the paddock. The 'Super Sub' of 2024 — a befitting term for the 19-year-old — was the one who initiated the rookie movement. And he could not have asked for a better place to start: the Ferrari garage. With team principal Fred Vasseur vouching for the young reserve driver, he got the prized opportunity to fill in for a recovering Carlos Sainz in Jeddah. With only one hour of on-track preparation, the last-minute substitute had a solid outing and finished a solid seventh on his debut.

Bearman would have hoped to take this newfound confidence into his F2 campaign with Prema Racing, but that wasn't the case. Considered one of the favourites to finish on top in his second F2 season, the British driver could secure only three wins. But, to his surprise, F1 came knocking on his door again.

He returned to take up his backup driver duties twice, both in place of Haas' Kevin Magnussen. Bearman managed to park the Haas in the final points place in Baku but couldn't get third-time lucky in Brazil. However, clean, damage-free drives and two top-10 finishes out of three were enough to guarantee him a



seat in 2025.

The new Haas recruit will need to be wary of his tricky teammate Esteban Ocon, but it will be just another challenge for this statement driver.

Jack Doohan

Seeing the name Doohan among the sport's competitors may turn a few heads among older motorsport fans, but rest assured — Jack Doohan's father Mick, a five-time MotoGP World Champion, has not decided to take up four-wheeled racing.

The 21-year-old (**below**), one of the first Alpine academy drivers to be promoted to F1, had a fairly decent time in the lower ranks (Top 3 in F2 and F3).

But a bold decision to move from Red Bull to Alpine gave him a better shot at racing among the best. He

got his first feel of an F1 car in 2021 before being announced as the team's reserve driver in 2023.

As a major contributor to the testing and development of the car, his consistent performances impressed the French outfit, putting an F1 seat within arm's reach.

Esteban Ocon's exit came as a blessing in disguise, as Jack was announced as Alpine's 2025 driver. Little did he know that he would get his first race in the same year, taking part in the Abu Dhabi Grand Prix.

His promotion prompted Alpine to bring in three more drivers to fill the vacant reserve slot — including Franco Colapinto, the fill-in Williams driver who stunned the paddock with the underperforming car.

Though Alpine has confirmed that Doohan will get ample time to prove his skills on track, an entire season to himself is not guaranteed.

